

The Yellow River

One of Asia's longest rivers, and the world's muddiest, the "Mother River" of the Chinese people



The most silt-laden river on Earth, the Yellow River takes its name from its coloration by the fine, windblown sediment, known as loess, that it carries along its lower course. It is the second longest river in China, after the Yangtze, and one of the longest in the world. After rising high on the Tibetan Plateau, the Yellow River follows an arching route eastward across the northern plains of China to the Yellow Sea, a journey of 3,393 miles (5,460 km).

Cradle to grave

Known as both China's Mother River and the Cradle of Chinese Civilization, the Yellow River historically sustained one of the country's most fertile and productive regions. However, the river basin is extremely prone to flooding, and a series of devastating floods has also earned the river the names the Ungovernable and China's Sorrow (see panel, right). As a result, much of the lower course of the Yellow River has been ramparted by levees and many of its tributaries have been dammed to control its flow.

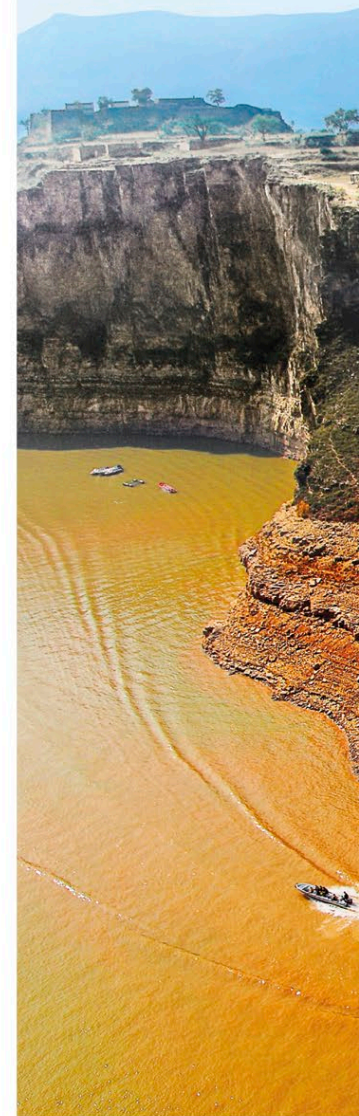


△ FIRST BEND

The Yellow River's upper course in Sichuan Province forms a huge S-shape, which is known as the First Bend.

◁ WIDE-RANGING TOAD

The Asiatic toad is common in China, living in a range of high-humidity habitats that include valleys and floodplains of the Yellow River. It eats beetles, bees, ants, and mollusks.



The Yangtze

Asia's longest river, flowing across eastern China from the Tibetan Plateau to the East China Sea; China's most commercially important river



Known in China as the Chang Jiang—"Long River"—the Yangtze is the longest river in Asia and the third longest in the world, after the Nile and the Amazon. From its glacier-fed source in the Tanggula Mountains on the Tibetan Plateau, to its mouth in the East China Sea, it flows 3,900 miles (6,300 km). The catchment area of the Yangtze covers one-fifth of the area of China and is home to one-third of the country's population.

Epic journey

On its journey across eastern China, the Yangtze flows through steep valleys, towering gorges, lake-strewn plains, and farmland, before forming a delta, where the megacity of Shanghai lies. Since 2006, the river's middle course has been regulated by the world's largest hydroelectric dam, the Three Gorges Dam, which has created a reservoir 370 miles (600 km) long. The Grand Canal—the longest human-made waterway on Earth at 1,100 miles (1,700 km)—links the lower section of the Yangtze to the Yellow River and Beijing to the north.



△ GOLD DUST RIVER

In its upper course, the river passes through the mountainous Yunnan Province. Here the Yangtze is known as the Jinsha Jiang, "Gold Dust River," due to the alluvial gold panned from its waters.